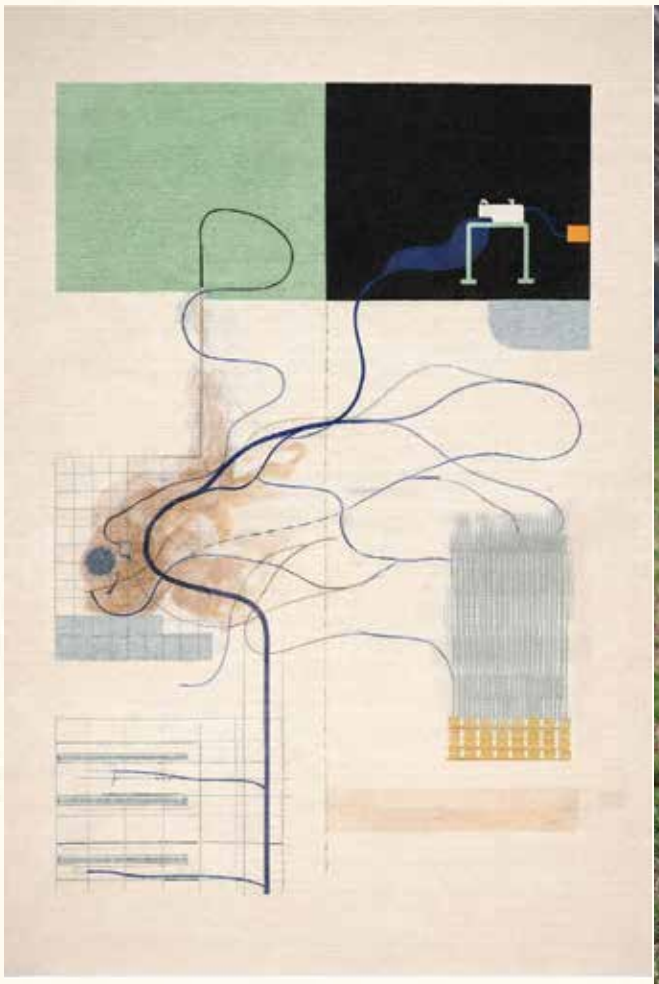
PORTFOLIO







Social Design Works

Mikiel Cassar

about..



Mikiel Cassar

As a **social designer and design anthropologist**, I have a deep interest in how **research, play, and collaboration** can generate **meaningful social interventions.**

My work combines collaborative ethnographic research with experimental design to create objects, systems, and experiences **that resonate at the cultural level and empower the users.**

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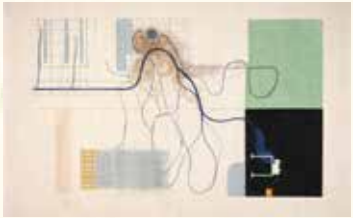
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Playground EcoSystem .1

activating space and adult play
Year: 2026
Type: Spatial Design
in collaboration with Tatiana Gomez

The Playground Ecosystem **is a behaviourally alive organism that grows and transforms through collective adult play.** Designed for DOPO? in Corvetto and based on its space sharing, coworking culture, **the system allows for users to playful construct their own space and environment**. Composed of two local species and one alien species, it survives only through symbiotic interaction. **Play becomes a tool to reclaim diversity, adaptability, and shared ownership in open space.**



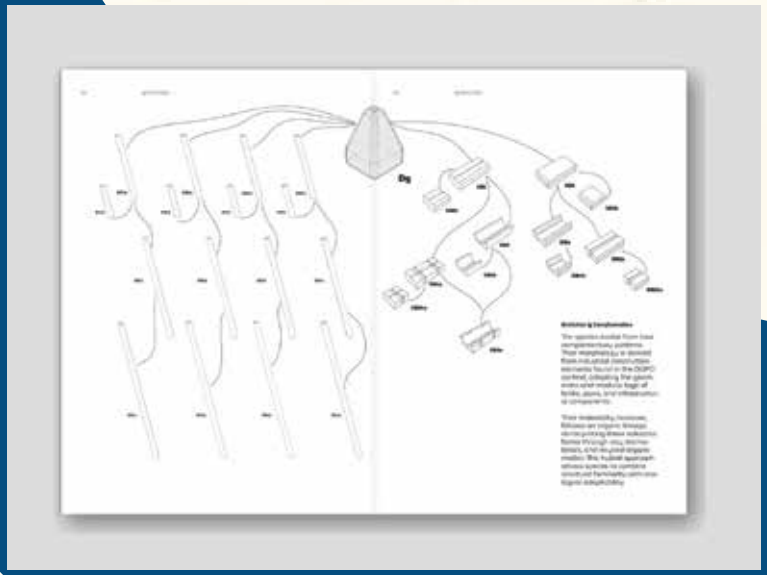
Brief and Research

As an ever-changing co-working space that hosts many events, the brief from DOPO? was to design something to **activate their space through adult play**.

To develop the concept, i**n-person interviews** and **extensive participant observation** of both events and working atmosphere were carried out. Through this the **workplace culture was mapped,** painting a malleable space that day to day did not provide moments to connect the different people and groups active in the space.

Playground EcoSystem .2







Football Arch



Benches







Ashtray



Playful and Mature

The ecosystem provides the creative opportunity for play whilst remaining grounded and engaging to key adults in.

Natural and Industrial

Based on the space, the ecosystem mixes natural textures and colours with industrial shapes to be noticeable but still at home.

Malleable and Permanent

The modular nature and physical weight allow for change to suit evolving needs but remain when untouched to communicate the culture of the space to new people.

Local and Alien

Inspired by the Corvetto area, the 2 local and 1 alien species of objects are made to interact and find ways to exist harmoniously just as local people and spaces balance the forces of gentrification.

A Modular ToolBox .1

empowering accessible work
Year: 2024
Type: Spacial Design

A Modular Toolbox was designed for Il Giardino, a local flower farm providing work experience to disabled youth**. It is designed to elevate work and provide purpose through providing moments of personal responsibility combined with the opportunity for creative use and problem solving.** Designed to be put together by the workers themselves, **the toolbox builds pride in one's work and its modular nature allows workers to work together**, combining their tool boxes to solve problems and heighten their work.





Brief and Research

As an active flower farm, the brief provided by Il Giardino was for any product that could elevate the space and work.

I**n-person interviews** with staff and workers were carried out, combined with **participant observation in the day to day farming**, revealing a work culture where there was **a need for accessible tools,** but also **a need for clear moments of personal responsibility** and a way to concretely and personally link workers to the space.





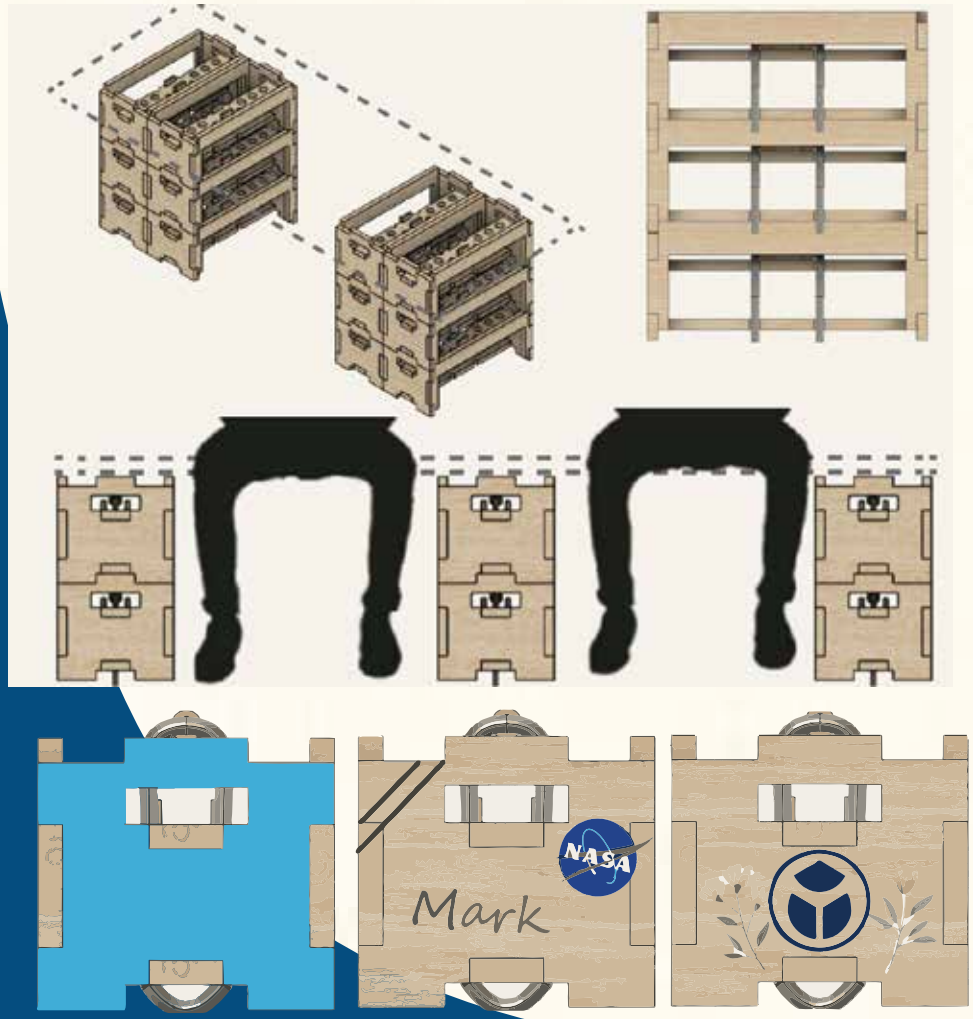
A Modular ToolBox .2











Meaningfully Supports Work

Cheaply and practically addresses a major issue on the farm of misplaced tools through an accessible design with many potential grips and holds.

Purpose and Identity Building

From personally making the toolbox, to caring for it, decorating it, the toolbox provides a concrete point to tie one's work and self to.

Personal Responsiblity

One can care for something that is directly their responsibility and track their tools and work, creating a clear way to continually see the impact of their work.

Elevating and Creative

By allowing for the toolbox to connect with each other in many ways, it encourages users to think how to creatively apply the box as more than just a box whilst calling the workers to interact with each other to combine their toolboxes together to solve problems or just have fun.

Reversed Echoes .1

exploration through play
Year: 2024
Type: Product and Event
in collaboration with Antonia Vlachopoulou

Created as a way for the residents of Sesto San Giovanni in Milan to **understand and interact with their own district**, this card game **reverses the experiences of students and residents back onto themselves**. Using the photos of students and the statements of locals, **the game reformats the familiar, creating a space for locals to reimagine the nature and future** of their district. Through a variety of game modes and exercises, **players meditate and discuss their space and its future through an intuitive discussion based format** accessible for all ages, easing them into these potentially hard but necessary discussions.

Brief and Research

The local cultural centre provided the brief to students to **create ideas, presentations, and objects to activate the local community.**

Through **extensive interviews with locals, photo mapping trips with students**, and extensive development workshops, the want of locals to have **a forum to discuss themselves** in along with an exciting way to do this became evident.









Reversed Echoes .2



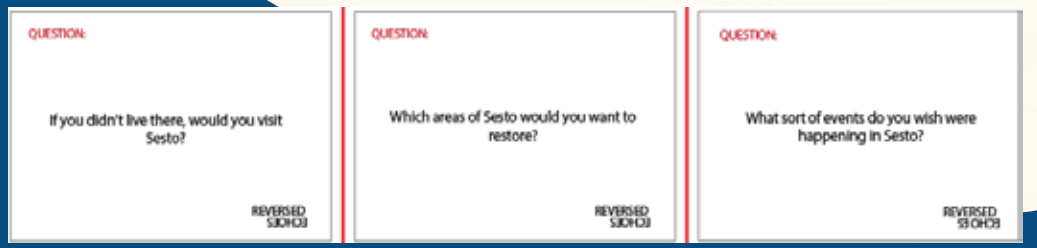












Accessible for all

The open-ended questions and captivating pictures combined with the various game modes ensure everyone can play, discussing deeply or quickly as they wish.

Engaging and replayable

The various modes and various cards ensure that each play through is different as people answer and engage differently to the prompts and images.

Multipurpose

Whether purely for fun, or in a workshop environement, or being used to learn about the district, the game can serve many purposes depending on the scenario.

Pride and Action Evoking

By presenting a different perspective that highlights the good and the bad of their disctict, the game allows the players to see the beauty of their disctict and what and where needs their action and support.

Tracing Aangan .1

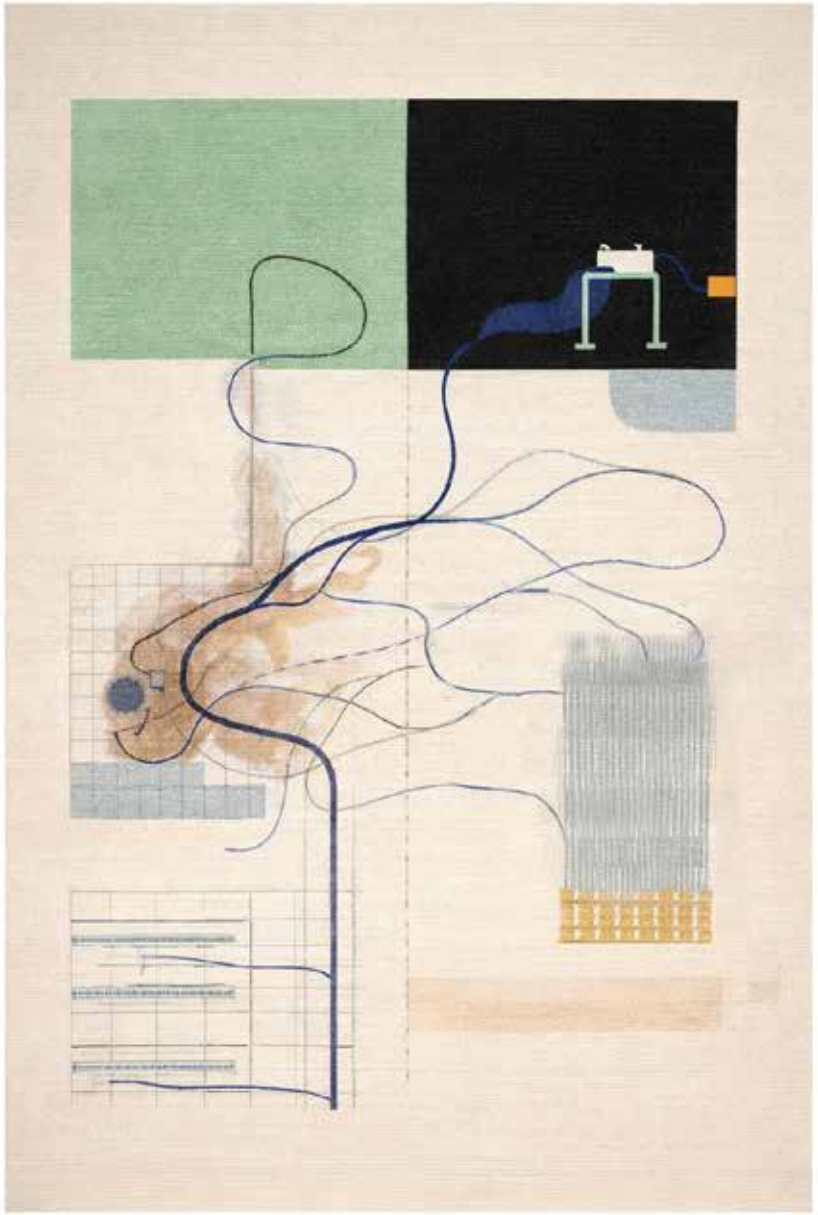
collaborative rug creation
Year: 2025
Type: Product and Event
in collaboration with Jacobo Ammirati

Inspired by the ways in which local Indian weavers in Jaipur lay out their homes, **this rug highlights the creative agency of the weavers, through their artistic practice but also their manipulation of space**. In collaboration with the Jaipur Rugs Foundation and based on Bourdieu's Theory of Space, t**he rug investigates how weavers utilise the relations between physical, social, and symbolic space to actively shape their futures**. Through this the weavers are elevated as whole persons with work but also life, with talents but also dreams, **all expressed through how they express their creative agency in every facet of life.**

Brief and Research

The Jaipur Rug Foundation invited us to Jaipur with the brief of developing new and **culturally resonant rug designs**.

After long periods of **participant observation** with the weavers in their homes and **workshop exercies** based around art and creation, the concepts of this rug came to the fore. It was revealed how the **intentionality of their use of space and the role of weaving** in their lives **were key players** that as of yet had not been highlighted as extensions of their will.



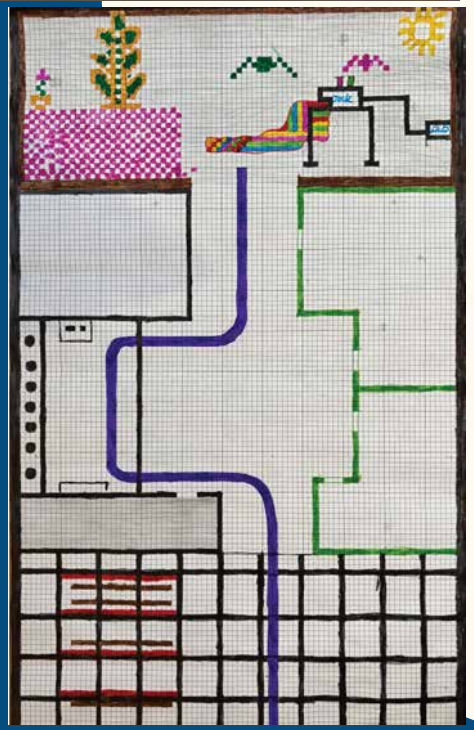


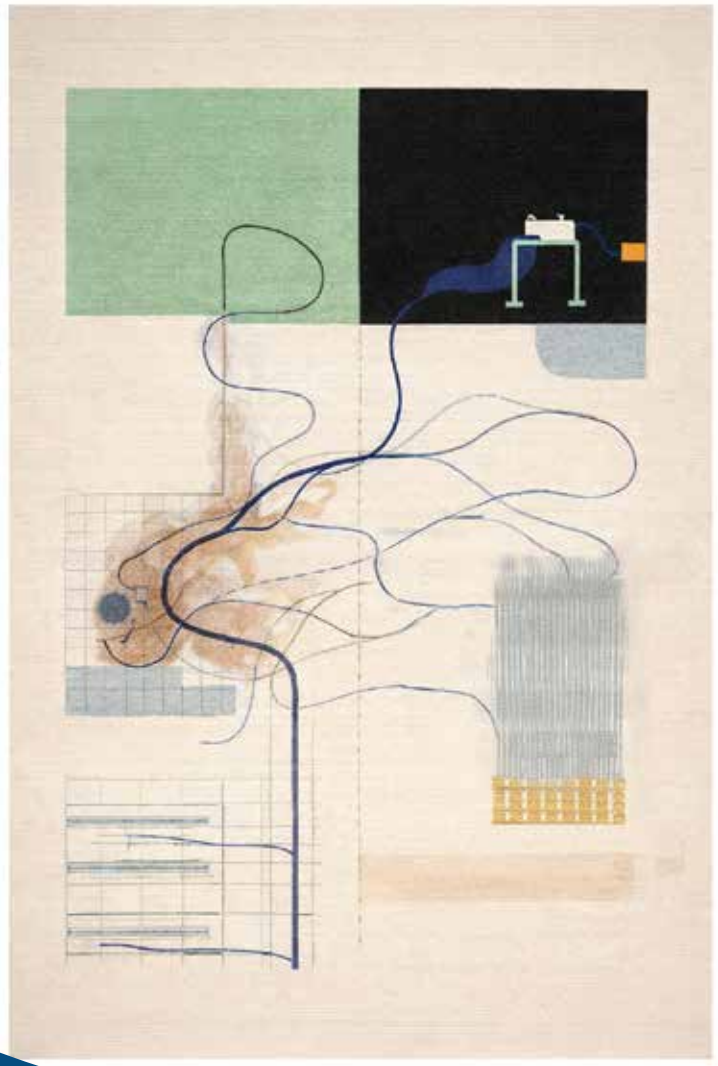




Tracing Aangan .2







Complex and Engaging

The rug mixes deep conceptual anthropological notions with local forms of representation and expression, fusing beauty and thought.

Collaboratively Designed

The rug was created hand in hand with the weavers, ensuring they are active artists in the process and they are not simply performatively represented but feel truly expressed through it.

Culturally Resonant

By intertwining these different elements and modes of expression, the rug invites all to interact, lying below and tracing the weavers' journey through their home and in turn their lives and futures.

Expandable

The concept for the rug was designed for the potential of it being applied to other homes and their floor plans, creating a range of rugs presenting the variety of creative expressions and agency.

Qlubi .1

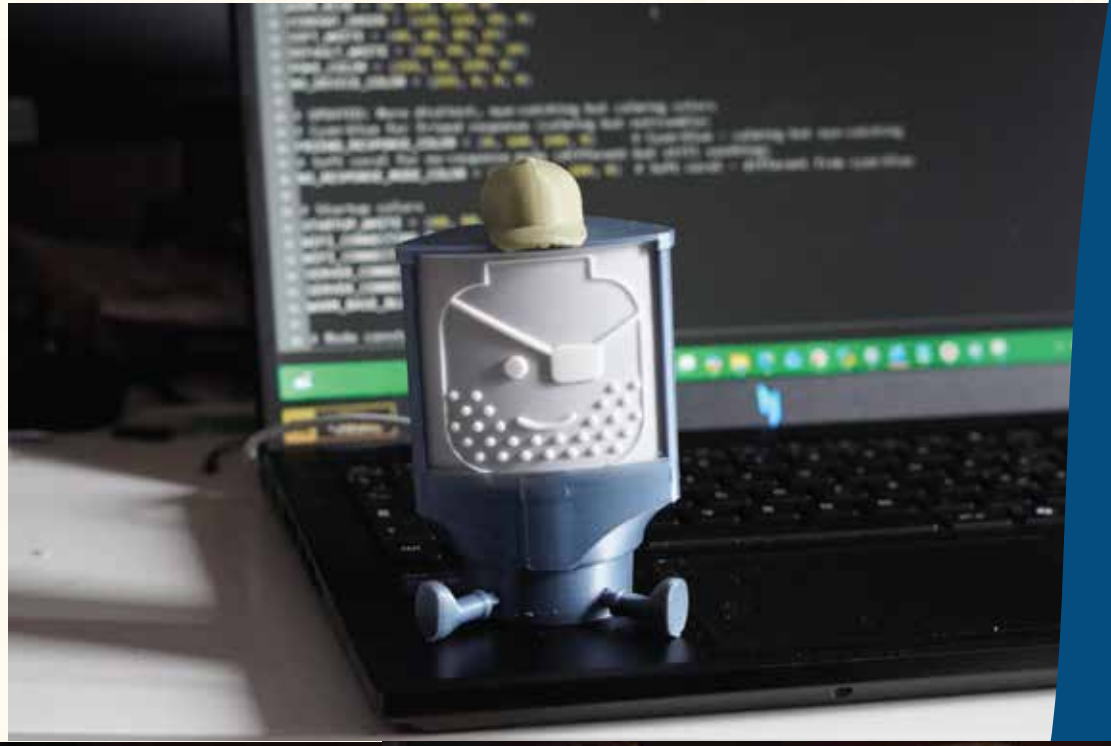
engaging connectivity
Year: 2026
Type: Product

Qlubi is a networked companion device **that converts heart rate stress signals into anonymous light communication**, enabling trusted groups to support each other remotely through subtle, non-verbal interaction. In today's world of digitally induced disconnect, this device fills that gap, **converting non-intentional physical signals into light based communication**. When someone in network is stressed, their Qlubi reaches out anonymously, allowing others to reach out and connect without being intrusive, **bringing that soft touch of connection through soothing pulses of light.**

Brief and Research

The brief presented was to create an **open source light based device** that incorporated some aspect of the social.

Broad investigation into the existing literature was undertaken to identify contemporary trends in behaviour and identify needs. **This revealed the growing sense of disconnect experienced by those working remotely** which in turn prompted research into the aspects of human communcation that are missed and how to translate these into a device.

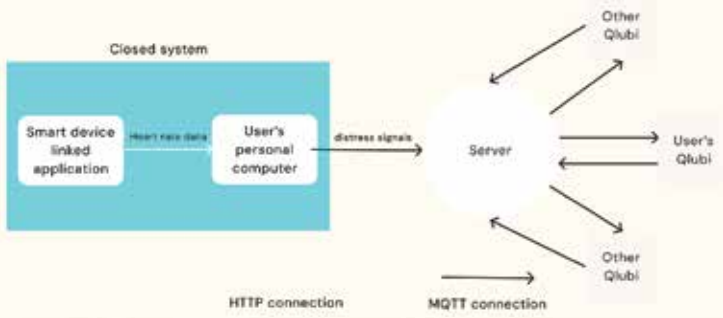




Qlubi .2







Engaging and Interactive

The device combines a unique set of features with a familiar form and mode of interaction, turning physical pats into digital connection.

Customisable and Adaptable

Qlubi is designed to be customised with different faces, hats, shoes, and colours but as a totally open source device users can continue to advance it as they see fit.

Private and Open

By keeping all user data and heart rate data local, the device ensures total privacy whilst still allowing for outward connection.

Soft and Supportive

Users are able to reach out without having to intentionally take those steps, meaning they can reach out when they do not know they are stressed and when they feel shy to.

Full product page:
https://github.com/makser-cisial/Qlubi-light-pal

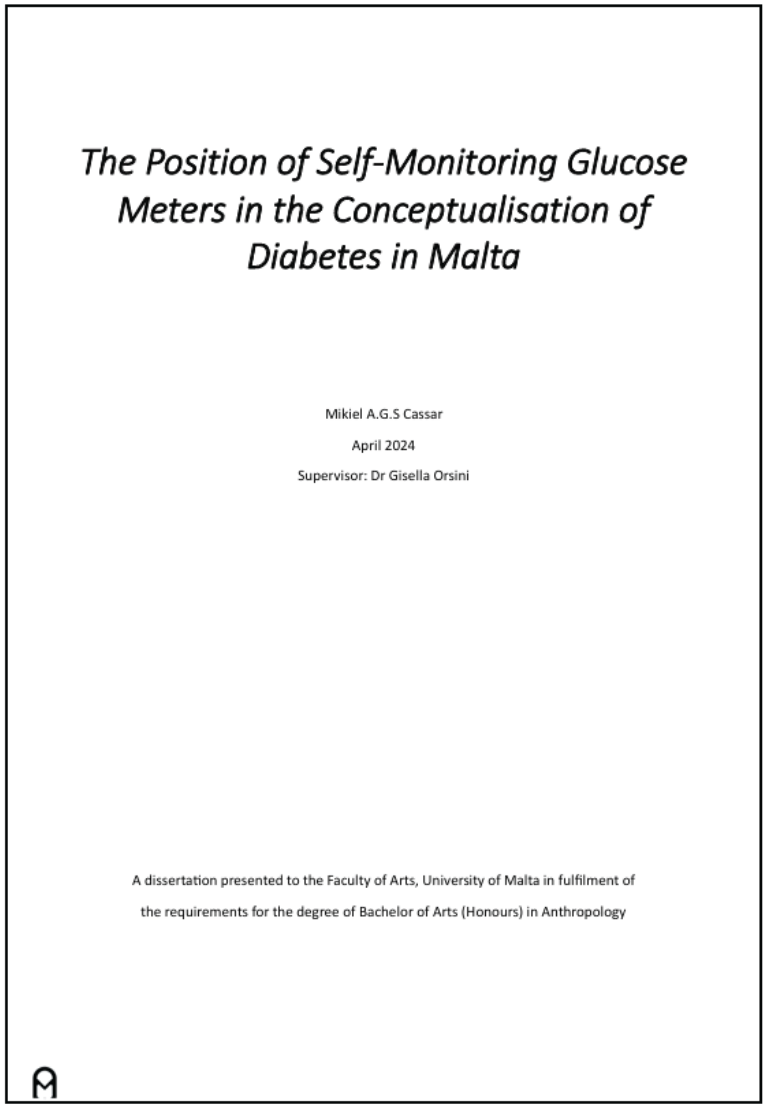
Academic Research

research and background
Year: 2024
Type: Rsearch

My work work examines the impact of medical device design on users' lives through the lens of design anthropology. **Design is never neutral**, and medical devices, though ostensibly objective, invariably reflect the worldviews of their creators. **When devices built around one conceptualisation of health meet are applied to others, the result is creative misappropriation rather than intended use**, revealing both the assumptions embedded in medical objects and the agency of those who use them. **The work concludes with design recommendations calling for a shift away from design that prescribes singular modes of use, towards plural design** that supports various models of health.

Research and Methods

The data supporting this research was collected through extensive ethnographic research carried out over 3 months. This involved extensive unstructure interviews and long streches of participant observation to learn how users are using their devices in their dailylives. This was accompanied by hands on participation where I used the medical device daily over the period of research. Complementing this was research in medical practitioners adn designers themselves to understand the user/designer dynamic.



The Position of Self-Monitoring Glucose Meters in the Conceptualisation of Diabetes in Malta

Mikiel A.G.S Cassar

April 2024

Supervisor: Dr Gisella Orsini

A dissertation presented to the Faculty of Arts, University of Malta in fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Arts (Honours) in Anthropology

Experience

Education

2024-2027
M.A. in Social Design
Nuova Accademia di Belle Arti

2021-2024
B.A. (Hons) in Anthropology with Sociology
University of Malta

2021
Certificate in Safeguarding Youth and Vulnerable Adults
Pastoral Foundation Institute Malta

Work Experience

2023-2026
Market Researcher
EMCS Malta

2023-2024
Junior Anthropologist (RSO)
University of Malta

Languages

English (Native)
Maltese (Native)
French (B1)
Italian (B1)

Soft Skills

Qualitative research
Quantitative research
Model making
Report writing
Curation
Workshop leading
Youth Work

Software

Fusion
AutoCad
Adobe Suite
Microsoft Office
R
Jamovi



I am interested in works that combine deep research with playfulness and creativity, with particular interest in design for disability and cultural translation. I have further interest in the development of product and company culture, particularly in engaging with the users' experience of it and their role in it.

Thank you for your consideration